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How did the development of agricultural capitalism create the ideology of "improvement"?

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Abstract

The results of the Brenner Debate produced an enhanced theory of transition from feudalism to capitalism based in rural 17th Century England. A key tenant of this school of thought is the role of "improvement" as both a motor in the divorce between peasants and their means of subsistence, and a consequence of newly created market imperatives both landlords and tenants were now subject too. The theory has been tested against quantitative measures such as rent and wage prices, produced from secondary sources, to see whether trends within said metrics agree with Brenner's theory of transition. With rental value volatility found to agree with the period outlined by Brenner. However regional difference in Norfolk suggestion that Wood's argument of the locality of the conditions required to produce agricultural capitalist phenomena are correct. Through an analysis of how primary sources used, measured and meant by improvement, insight may be gained into the validity of the Brenner-Wood theory. It is found that improvement ideology primarily aimed to increase absolute agricultural yield as opposed to production efficiency. This is testimony to the transitionary nature of the period in which labour commodification and capitalist laws of motion were still nascent. Finally an analysis is performed of what signifiers characterise this previous change in the mode of production, giving insight into the next transition with a focus on ecological disaster.

Contents

1 Introduction **3**
1.1 Methods . . . 3

2 Marx on the transition **4**
2.1 Primitive Accumulation . . . 4

3 The Brenner debate **5**
3.1 Brenner's theory of transition . . . 5
3.2 Wood's schism with Brenner . . . 6

4 Further evidence for the role of market imperatives in the English economy **6**
4.1 Evolution of rents in the Manor of Brinkworth . . . 6
4.2 Macro studies into the evolution of rent and labour . . . 7
4.3 Feudalism and ecological disaster . . . 10
4.4 *The State of England Anno Dom. 1600* . . . 10

5 Historicising improvement **12**
5.1 *The English Improver Improved* . . . 12
5.2 William Petty . . . 13
5.3 John Locke . . . 14

6 Conclusions **15**

7 Acknowledgements **17**

Go tell the World of Wealth that's got with ease, Of certain profit (gain most men doth please) Of Lands Improvement to a treble worth, A Five, a tenfold Plenty's here held forth; The greedy Land-Lord may himself suffise, The toyling tenant to estate may rise, The poor may be enricht, England supplyid For twice so many people to provide; Though this a Paradox may seem to you, Experience and Reason proves it true; By floating dry, and purging Boggy Land, The Plough old Pasture betters to your hand; Directions to Inclose, to all mens gain, Minerals found out, Land rich'd with little pain; Woods ordred so, in few years yeeld such store, So large, so good as you'l desire no more. In fine, all Land in each Capacity, In which it lies, made Pleasant to your eye.

Captain Walter Blith - 1649

1 Introduction

"Men make their own history, but they do not make it as they please; they do not make it under self-selected circumstances, but under circumstances existing already, given and transmitted from the past" [Marx, 1852]. Marx's view that individuals adhere to the imperatives that govern the reproduction of their own class may be used as the basis off which to analyse the transition from feudalism to capitalism. According to [Comninel, 2000, p.10] feudalism may be defined as a mode of production in which the ruling class extracts surplus value from direct producers via non-economic means, often political and under the threat of force. In contrast, capitalism extracts surplus value from labourers, who are not direct producers and do not posses the means of production, via economic means. Capitalists must re-invest the extracted surplus value, in order to reproduce their class position, to keep up with increasing productivity. Through an analysis of the transition from one class structure to another, one might hope to gain insights into common identifiers which are associated with the collapse of a mode of production. Improvement ideology emerged in the mid 16th Century composed of both practical methods to increase the output of a given piece of land, and as a method through which to better the condition of the English peoples, as argued by Captain Walter Blith.

This essay aims to fully evaluate the validity of claims made regarding improvement within the Brenner and Wood theories of transition. To achieve this Marx's theory of transition is examined, focusing on the idea of primitive accumulation and how this produced a framework for later Marxist historians. Subsequently an overview of the Brenner debate is preformed. Studying, its causes, how it evolved transitional theory as well as where Robert Brenner diverted with fellow Political Marxist Ellen Meiksins Wood over market imperatives versus market dependence. In order to provide an alternative angle of evaluation, quantitative secondary sources and primary sources are examined as evidence for Brenner and Wood's transitionary theory. The focus being how Brenner and Wood's predictions for the effect of improvement ideology might be expressed in the relevant quantitative metrics. The role of improvement in historical literature during the transition is examined to find discrepancy between its historic use and the terms use in Brenner and Wood's theories. Focusing on how improvement and labour were described and measured. As well as laying out how historical philosophical and political writers, influenced by the ideology of improvement, acted as theorists for agricultural capitalism. Finally, an analysis is preformed of what the transition from feudalism to the current mode of production may tell us about the next transition. The essay does not look at comparisons with other countries during the transition in England, the relation of agricultural capitalism to the industrial revolution, or deals with critiques of the Brenner and Wood's theories from non-Marxist sources.

1.1 Methods

Due to time limitations of the project the primary sources analysed were all taken from online databases in transcribed digital formats. An attempt was made to overcome this limitation through a wide study of secondary

literature, also aiming to incorporate sources that were not directly linked to the Brenner Debate as to inform it from an alternative perspective. This limitation was also partly caused by a lack of experience with paleography which meant sources were sought after with an eye to maximise legibility. This meant the scope of possible primary texts to study was limited. As a consequence a significant part of the project centred on finding previously unstudied primary sources, or approached well-studied sources from a different analytic aim.

2 Marx on the transition

2.1 Primitive Accumulation

Marx argued against the inevitability of capitalism, comparing it to the “original sin” in theology [Marx, 1894, p.507]. Where capitalism’s “origin is supposed to be explained when it is told as an anecdote of the past" [Marx, 1894, p.507]. Marx instead produced a theory based off the end result and its defining characteristics of wage co-modification and the separation of the means of production from wage-employees. For Marx the transformation of goods into capital requires a social transformation in the relations between the producer and the ruling class. This process Marx labels Primitive Accumulation. He identified the "expropriation of the self-supporting peasants" as a factor but also ”the destruction of rural domestic industry" [Marx, 1894, p.531]. The former of which is the first step in the formation of capital, drawing a distinction between feudal wealth and capital. Marx states ”what enables money-wealth to become capital is the encounter, on one side, with free workers; and on the other side, with the necessaries and materials etc, which previously were in one way or another the property of the masses who have now become object-less, and are also free and purchasable" [Marx, 2005]. Marx identifies this process of dispossession as having two components, firstly the “forcible driving of the peasantry from [their] land" and secondly a “usurpation of the common lands" [Marx, 1894, p.514]. With both factors Marx uses Francis Bacon’s “History of the Reign of King Henry VII" to pinpoint historical legislation off the back of which much of this dispossession was carried out. For Marx these tendencies contributed to a final state of a “degraded and almost servile condition of the mass of the people, the transformation of them into mercenaries, and of their means of labour into capital" [Marx, 1894, p.511]. This degradation of the peasantry can be seen in the collapse of the independent yeoman who was replaced by tenants who depended on yearly leases. Producing “a servile rabble dependent on the pleasure of the landlords" [Marx, 1894, p.511]. This available labour was now “transformed into material elements of variable capital" [Marx, 1894, p.530] thereby introducing the final components for the transition, “ the peasant, expropriated and cast adrift, must buy their value in the form of wages, from his new master, the industrial capitalist" [Marx, 1894, p.530]. For Marx it is a combination of social relations and material conditions that produces the banality of capitalist economic logic resulting in “the subjugation of the labourer to the capitalist" [Marx, 1894, p.523].

In his analysis Marx had a very limited mention of improvement language. Suggesting the ”revolution in the conditions of landed property was accompanied by improved methods of culture, greater co-operation, concentration of the means of production" [Marx, 1894, p.530]. This lack of involvement of improvement within Marx’s theory of transition could in part be explained by a lack of access to many of the primary sources used by the likes of Brenner and Woods in constructing their own theories. But also speaks to the fact that Marx was first and foremost a philosopher not a historian.

3 The Brenner debate

3.1 Brenner's theory of transition

With the publication of "Agrarian Class Structure and Economic Development in Pre-Industrial Europe" in 1976 Robert Brenner produced a crucial advance in the causes of the very first case study of the transition from feudalism to capitalism. It is in this very word "transition" that Brenner argued even Marxist historians such as Paul Sweezy or Maurice Dobb had been led astray [Brenner, 1977, p.41-53], emphasising that they were assuming an a priori exisistence of an embryonic capitalism within feudal society[1]. Brenner's theory sought internal conflicts within feudalism, as opposed to an external impetus, which might produce its collapse. Wood offers an analysis that " it [was] a matter of lords and peasants, in certain specific conditions peculiar to England, involuntarily setting in train a capitalist dynamic while acting in class conflict with each other to reproduce themselves as they were" [Wood, 2002a, p.52]. This focus on the class conflict nature of the transition is what distinguished Brenner and Wood's theory from other contemporary Political Marxists. Brenner identifies the internal logic of feudalism that inhibits surplus reinvestment. For the feudal lord it was often easier to find new avenues to "squeeze" [Brenner, 1976, p.74] out more absolute surplus value from their subjects instead of increasing their labour efficiency. Due to the fact that a lord's power was directly correlated to size of the population under his control this lead to a focus on labour immobility, and maximising the ease with which he could extract surplus value from his peasants by non-economic means. Resulting in restrictions on land mobility and "unfree peasants [unable] to convey their land to other peasants without the lord's permission" [Brenner, 1976, p.50].

The centuries previous to the 17th Century were characterised by the end of serfdom in England, resulting in peasants whose lords extracted surplus value partly through the rent of their land. These were customary rents that decreased in value for the lord over time due to inflation. This loss in income revenue was counteracted through the imposition of arbitrary fines on peasants wherever land was sold or inherited. However over the 15th and 16th centuries landlords successfully crushed peasant land rights in order to combat this decreasing power. This decay in freehold rights meant that lord could slowly accumulate large demesne holdings, which could be leased out to larger tenants [Hoyle, 1990, p.7]. Who in turn sub-let to smaller farmers or employed wage labourers. This new wave of larger tenancies brought two new sources of market imperatives, firstly the lord had to keep his rents competitive as he was now trying to undercut the rest of the domestic tenancy market, given that the larger tenant had the ability to move away. Secondly the tenant had to compete on a goods market, requiring them to sell the products of their husbandry in order to make enough profit to fulfil market dependant rent. This required a shift from production for subsistence to production for sale. These two forces resulted in a new weakly symbiotic relation between lord and capitalist tenant in which both were driven to re-invest surplus value back into their land, thereby improving agricultural yields and transforming feudal wealth into capital. This established a new set of laws of motion in which the lord and tenant were compelled to improve their agricultural yields in order to self-replicate their class condition. Brenner claims that "agricultural improvement not only made it possible for an ever greater proportion of the population to leave the land to enter industry" [Brenner, 1976, p.67] but also mean that a larger proportion of the domestic population was no longer involved in agriculture, freeing peasants to become the wage labour required for "England's continued industrial growth" [Brenner, 1976, p.67] through the 17th Century.

[1]Several theories of transition may be grouped as commercial models. The keystone of these theories is that capitalism arose as the barriers for its development were removed [Wood, 2002a, p.12]. Crucially, the driving factor behind this development was man's "propensity to truck, barter, and exchange" [Smith and Stewart, 1963]. This force led to the division of labour and ultimately industrial capitalism. Brenner and Wood's fundamental critique of this approach is that it assumes a nascent agricultural or industrial capitalism within other modes of production, such that there is no real transition and capitalism was inevitable [Wood, 2002a, p.51].

3.2 Wood's schism with Brenner

Wood and Brenner disagreed on the specifics of market dependence versus market imperatives. Wood argued that Brenner's analysis of the supposed development of capitalism in the low countries went against the very logic he himself had set out, with the conflict lying in how Brenner had applied the idea of market dependence outside of England. For Wood the difference between market dependence, according to Brenner, and market imperatives as the driving factor mediating production in a capitalist market is ”not opportunity or choice, but, on the contrary, compulsion" [Wood, 2002a, p.7] to obey the market. She identified two different types of market dependence, one present in commercial societies, such as the Dutch republic, in which there was a "need to exchange in order to survive" [Wood, 2002b, p.85], and a second form "that makes profit-maximization, not consumption or exchange, the immediate object of production" [Wood, 2002b, p.85]. Attributing the latter to the English economy. Thus wood identified that the new class structure of agricultural capitalism was founded firmly in the ”market-dependence of both exploiter and exploited" [Wood and Patriquin, 2012, p.11].

4 Further evidence for the role of market imperatives in the English economy

Critics of Brenner and Wood have argued that this new development in the theory of transition is fundamentally incorrect [Denemark and Thomas, 1988, Albritton, 1993, Duchesne, 2001], with some instead pushing for the view that Marx's own analysis is sufficient [Katz, 1993, Astarita, 2018]. Others instead offers a view that Brenner and Wood's focus on the evolution of the nature of rent and its market dependence is unjustified, instead offering alternative parameters to explain the transition [Jones, 2019, Bryer, 2000a, Bryer, 2000b]. In order to fully evaluate Brenner and Wood's theories one must provide quantitative evidence testing both their own historical evidence and predictions made by the theory with regards to changes in agricultural yields due to improvement.

4.1 Evolution of rents in the Manor of Brinkworth

The manor of Brinkworth, Wiltshire, provides a small scale case study for the changing nature of rents over the period 1587-1625. Three manorial roles were studied, containing varying accuracy and amount of information. These are generally composed of a list of tenants, the nature of the tenancy, a lease period and the annual rent collected. Beginning with the decay of the yeomanry and freehold tenancy in 1587 there was 1 freehold tenant and 4 customary long term tenancies holding a collective 177 acres each for a tenancy ”by indenture for the term of 2000 years", with a total rent of 20 shillings and 2 pence. However by 1602 these freehold and long term tenancies had reduced to 161 acres representing a 9% decrease, for the same collected rent. By 1625 this had reduced to 1 tenant with a yearly rental income of 12 pence. The number of customary and copyholders is harder to track as in 1587 they are listed separately whilst in 1602 they are jointly listed and in 1625 they are recorded as ordinary and copyhold leases.

The numbers of tenants listed varies from 83 to 87 to 67, perhaps demonstrating a concentration of land holdings over the period. However the reliability of the records are questionable given the large variability in the quality of the recorded from one role to the next as the total acreage is 1776.75 in 1587, 173.5 in 1602 and unlisted in 1625. This discrepancy being due to the 1602 manorial roll missing acreage details for large proportions of the roll. Yet a basic conclusion to take from these records is that there is evidence to be found for the decreasing strength of the traditional yeomanry and growth of the number of shorter tenancies with weaker tenants rights, as identified by Brenner.

4.2 Macro studies into the evolution of rent and labour

In order to fully evaluate the evidence supporting the claims of Brenner and Wood, more holistic studies of the evolution of wages and and rents over a period spanning from the middle ages to the industrial revolution are required. Such macro studies were first assembled by the likes of Sir Henry Phelps Brown and Sheila Hopkins [Brown and Hopkins, 1956] and aim to produce a continuous metric throughout the early modern period. Often these metrics use data such as that outlined previously in the Manor of Brinkworth, but on a much larger scale. This data is normalised to account for variations in the location of where the data is collected and period during which it is collected. Figure 1 shows the ratio of arable to pasture prices between 1209 and 1914 with data points

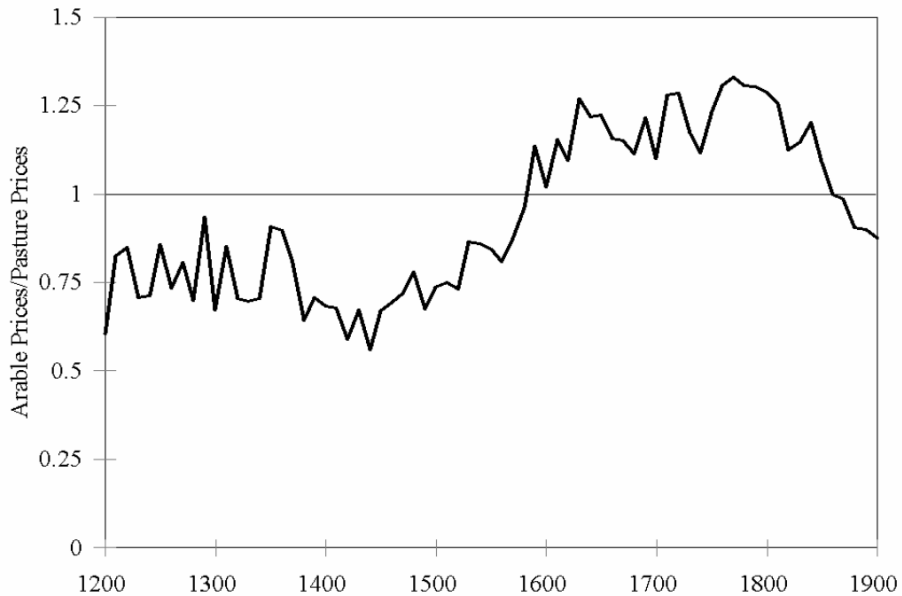

Figure 1: Ratio of arable to pasture prices [Clark, 2004]. Note the increasing ratio from the mid 15th Century until the early 17th Century. This perhaps contradicts Brenner's theory as there is no drop in agricultural prices due to increased supply from improvement.

produced for each decade. The evolution of the ratio of the may split into several periods. An initial stable value throughout the late medieval period, a steady increase from the mid 15th Century until the early $17th$, and finally a dip from the early 19th. The last of which Clark attributes to the development of refrigerated ships, causing a rise in imports of pastoral good, resulting in lower prices. The theory set out by Brenner and Wood would suggests that the primary affect of improvement would lead to a decrease in the price of arable products as the supply of said products increased throughout the agricultural revolution. Clark suggests that instead improvements in livestock breeding and husbandry during the 16th could be the root of this increase in the ratio. Thus this metric appears to contradict the initial claims made by Brenner and woods of the birth of a agricultural capitalism, instead suggesting a earlier revolution in pastoral improvement.

The Brenner and Woods theory of transition is fundamentally one of change regarding the natural of rental relations in England, thus the value of said rents is by association also of great importance. This theory might been seen to predict a radical change in the value of rents during the late 16th Century and early 17th Century as the English economy adjusted to the increasing marketization of land.

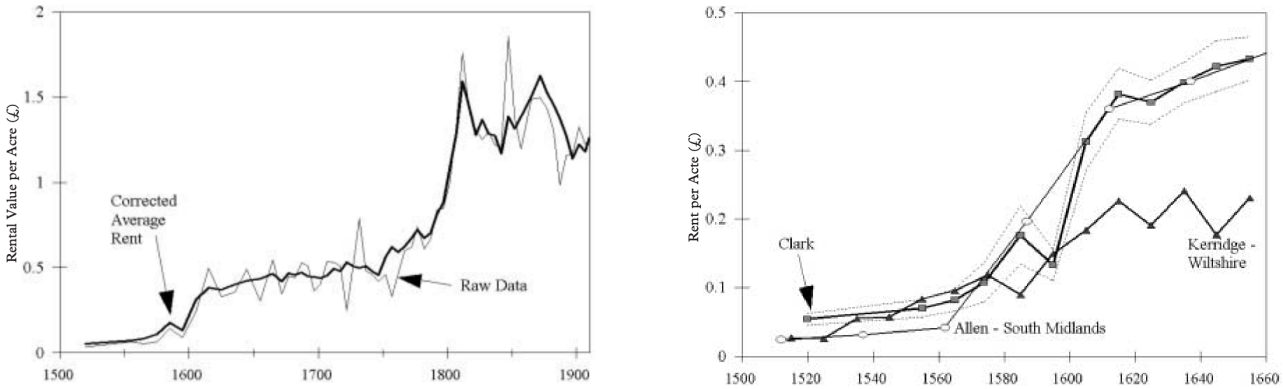

Figure 2: Left: Evolution of rental value per acre over time. Note the sharp increase in value during the early 17th Century. Right: A comparison of multiple studies of rental value per acre over this crucial period in the transition from feudalism to agricultural capitalism [Clark, 2002]. The rapid increase shown in the left hand figure produced by Clark's data is a common feature of both Allen's and Kerridge's studies as well [Clark, 2002, Allen, 1988, Kerridge, 1953]

Figure 2 left indicates that Clark's data matches this prediction. With a defined increase in rental value from from the mid 16th until the 1620s, with a more gradual increase until the early 18th Century. It is important to note that the data see in Figure 2 left is sourced exclusively from charitable trusts and ignores customary rents, focusing on rents with a competitive market [Clark, 2002, p.282]. However, given the rapidly decreasing proportion of customary rents over this period, as shown by [Hoyle, 1990] and the Brinkworth manorial roles, conclusions regarding changes in rental values are valid, but not those regarding the level to which rents were subject to market imperatives. Similarly in Figure 2 right, a comparison with two other similar studies, there is the same stark and rapid increase in real rent values. The role of improvement within this period must be seen as a reaction to this volatile rental market, in which tenants had to increase their profits to be able to pay competitive rents. Figure 3

Figure 3: Evolution of real wages between 1500 and 1914 [Clark, 2002]. Note the volatility in the ratio during the late 16th Century to early 17th Century, suggesting a radical change in the rental market but limited variation in wages and by extension wage commodification. This emphasises the transitionary nature of the period as labour commodification was not fully formed.

describes the evolution of the ratio of rents to farm wages from 1500 to 1912. Similarly to Figure 2 left the early 17th may be seen as a volatile period. Overall Figure 2 and Figure 3 demonstrate the power and wealth transfer during the transitory period to those large land owning lords who were able to effectively compete in the land market [Clark, 2002, p.305]. Whilst there may have been changes in labour values during the period the changes in rental value dominate the evolution of Figure 3. Thus demonstrating limited or at least not radical changes in how labour was valued,and by proxy the limited extent of labour commodification over the period.

In measuring the effect of improvement during the period of interest grain output may be used a characterising metric for agricultural yield. Figure 4 shows the changing grain output and grain wage labour over the period 1540 to 1800. There is a sustained increase from the mid 16th Century until the mid 17th Century. This corresponds with an increasing role of improvement over this period, as argued by the several historical sources outlined previously. Crucially, the increase in productivity associated with the industrial revolution began much earlier than the mechanisation of labour. Clark attributes the increase over the period not to a real increase in labour productivity but instead to an increase in the acreage available. Counter intuitively this claim supports the new role of improvement in the English economy, as another key tenant of this ideology was the reclaiming and expansion of arable land as outlined by works such as *The English Improver Improved*, see Section 5.1. Using

Figure 4: Grain wage and grain output in Britain from 1541 to 1860 [Clark, 1991]. Note the continual rise in output until 1650, coinciding with a decrease farm wages until the 1620s.

[Campbell and Overton, 1993], a study of the agriculture in Norfolk from 1250 to 1850, allows for the comparison of how regional variation in metrics compare to the nation wide ones previously examined. To begin with Norfolk appears to buck the medieval agricultural yield trend, with a lack of decreasing productivity as the local population increased [Campbell and Overton, 1993, p.74]. Instead agricultural yields were higher before the black death and increased whenever populations were rising such as 1584-99 and 1628-40. For the authors the boost in agricultural productivity associated with Brenner's theory of agricultural capitalism comes much later during the 18th Century not the 17th [Campbell and Overton, 1993, p.74]. They identifying a switch from agricultural produce to livestock that began in the late 14th Century and continued into the early 16th Century. Norfolk reverses the ownership trend,

with sheep becoming the landlord animal, as opposed to the growing focus on agricultural products emphasised by Brenner. In the place of an agricultural revolution Campell and Overton offer a revolution in stocking densities in drawing the line between medieval and early modern Norfolk, as by the 17th Century stocking densities were double those of the 14th Century [Campbell and Overton, 1993, p.84].

Whilst the conclusions of the article do not bode well for Brenner and Wood's theory at first glance, some consideration must be taken, as admitted by the authors themselves, "Norfolk is not England, still less Britain, and much useful work remains to be done reconstructing developments in the rest of the country" [Campbell and Overton, 1993, p.104]. One of the key aspects that differentiates Wood's from Brenner is her emphasis on the locality of the phenomena that characterised the birth of agricultural capitalism. This speaks to a wider point outlined by Wood that the agricultural capitalism was not a necessary outcome of feudalism in Europe. More specifically agricultural capitalism was not even the only possible outcome within the English state itself, as is evidenced when the nation studies outlined above are combined with that performed by Campell and Overton.

4.3 Feudalism and ecological disaster

An alternative angle from which to approach the issue of transition, is that of seeing how the mode of production affects the environment and what this may tell us about changes in agricultural yields. In "Nature and the Transition from Feudalism to Capitalism" Moore argues the effect of the mode of surplus extraction characterising feudalism led to the slow decay of soil fertility. Whereby the contradictions within feudalism produced long term ecological disaster as lack of surplus re-investment resulted in "little manure; little manure had meant low yields; with low corn yields per acre, every possible scrap of land had to be ploughed for corn" [Davis, 1973, p.113]. This, in combination with feudalism's main source of generating more surpluses being increasing the population, inevitably led to the Malthusian cycles. With Moore emphasising that "the transition to capitalism was enabled by a biological regime that placed the (mal)nutritional burden on the bellies of the direct producer" [Moore, 2003, p.157]. However the result of this Malthusian cycle ending in agricultural capitalism was not an alleviation of this ecological crisis but instead its worsening. With capitalism requiring a continual expansion of both land and labour in the service of capital, this is exemplified in both the reclamation of land through the improvement movement or the exploitation of colonial lands. This growth alleviates the internal contradictions of capitalism as long as they are sustained. It is through this initial ecological crisis that characterised the birth period of capitalism that Moore argues for the direct link between environmental and class relations in the modern age. Moreover Wood argued that the large scale of the 2001 foot an mouth disease was of no surprise, given that such ecological disasters were a direct product of the origins of agricultural capitalism, intensive farming[Wood, 2002a, p.189]. The same underlying ecological catastrophe are repeated today, as they were once in the 17th Century, caused by the same underlying capitalist laws of motion. Whilst the expression of this capitalist mode of production may have changed from agricultural capitalism the same underlying market imperatives identified by Wood still remain.

4.4 *The State of England Anno Dom. 1600*

The youngest son of a country gentlemen Thomas Wilson would not inherit any of his fathers land, instead he went on to fulfil a wide range of occupations such as judge, diplomat, spy, archivist, master of a Cambridge college and author. Given this breadth and family background, Wilson's book *The State of England Anno Dom. 1600*, provided unique insight into early modern England from a character that understood the inner workings of the landlord-tenant-labourer triad.

One can see in Wilson's writing many of the same themes later identified by modern historians such as Brenner and Wood regarding the decline of the peasantry in the late 16th Century, the changing nature of rents and the emerging ideology of improvement. Wilson focuses on the evolution of the gentry from addicts of war to "good husbandes"[Wilson, 1601, p.19] who know "how to improve their lands to the uttermost as the farmer or countryman" [Wilson, 1601, p.19]. Consequentially this produced a change in the nature of the rental relationship between lord and tenant, as the former took back control of their farms. Allowing the generous leases of the 15th Century to expire then "eyther till themselves or else lett them out to those who will give most" [Wilson, 1601, p.19]. It is this latter statement that adds great weight to Brenner's argument for the market dependency of rents during this period, as Wilson himself identified the market relationship between lord and tenant.

For Wilson the class character of 17th Century England was dependant on two factors, possession of land, and dependency on wage labour for subsistence. This is exhibited through his identification the decay of the traditional great yeomanry and the growth of the "cominality" [Wilson, 1601, p.19]. Evidence for the decay of the yeomanry is found in the fact that the traditional yeomanry was no longer able to lend the Queen money, with Wilson lamenting that their numbers had dwindled to 10000 yeomen and identified another 80,000 freeholders of "meaner ability" [Wilson, 1601, p.19]. Additionally, in cases where the yeomanry still held onto their long customary leases, Wilson argued that the "yonge masters the sonnes of such" who are "not contented with their states of their fathers to be counted yeoman" [Wilson, 1601, p.19] are removed from their fathers customary lands when the leases expire "which was never wont to be done, the farmer accounting his state as good as inheritance in tymes past" [Wilson, 1601, p.19]. Therefore Wilson does not fully agree with Brenner in his explanation of the decay of the yeomanry, instead partly blaming the laziness of the sons of the yeomanry who "skipp into [their] velvett breches and silken dublett" [Wilson, 1601, p.19]. In contrast the Great yeomanry and freeholders, the remaining population is identified as copyholders and Cottagers who had some "parcel of the demeisne" [Wilson, 1601, p.20] of the lord. This peasantry is characterised by Wilson as poor and "[living] chefly upon contry labor workeing by the day for meat and drinke and some small wages" [Wilson, 1601, p.20]. Therefore we see an evolution in the class relations of England during this period as the possession of land no longer guaranteed the power and status traditionally held, as exhibited by the decay of the yeomanry and the growth of the wage earning cominality.

Wilson sets out an explanation for the former rise of the yeomanry in England at the expense of the gentry. It agrees with Brenner's theory of market dependence and not some active policy implemented through the state. Arguing for "the substelty of them and simplicity of gentle- men" [Wilson, 1601, p.38]. Wilson states that "lordships and could not occupy all their lands themselves, but placed farmers therein" [Wilson, 1601, p.38]. Due to the scarcity of money and decaying rent prices " the yeomen and farmers told the gentlemen, their landlords, that they could not be at so great charges to manure and inclose and improve their grounds, and repaire and reedify their houses ruined by warr" [Wilson, 1601, p.39]. Unless the gentry provided cheap rents with the remainder of lost income being supplanted by "peece of money for a fyne" [Wilson, 1601, p.39]. Leading to leases lasting "30, some 40 and some 50 some 200 yeares" [Wilson, 1601, p.39]. Wilson contrasts Brenner by identifying the crucial role of improvement within the growth of yeoman power. This disagreement stems from the fact that Wilson argues for a yeomanry who is elevated into a position of power some years before the start of the 17th Century due to the development of improvement ideology. Therefore, acording to Wilson, improvement was a important factor in the 15th and early 16th Century, when the yeomanry was at its peak, however it was not the cause of the changing socio-economic relation between lord and tenant.

5 Historicising improvement

To give further weight to the arguments made by Brenner and Wood an analysis of how improvement is used in language in historical sources is required to compare to how they are used by said historians. One of the first examples of a main stream use of the term improvement was in John Fitzherbert's "Surveying and Improvements" produced in 1523, the first appearance of improvement on a book title page [Slack, 2014, p.27]. On the other hand a dictionary published in 1613 described improvement as simply "raising rents" [Slack, 2014, p.5]. What was meant by the term improvement must be established by studying how it was used within the context of historical texts relating to agricultural capitalism. A obvious entry point for this study is by examining classical improvement literature and the works of theorists of agricultural capitalism.

5.1 *The English Improver Improved*

Written by Captain Walter Blith in 1649 *The English Improver Improved* is a brilliant case study for the genre of improvement literature that appeared during the 17th Century. The target audience being lords and capitalist tenants aiming to increase the yield of their lands and thus enrich themselves. To this end Blith addresses each social strata in the introduction of the book, specifying how each might benefit. Following this, the author provides details on improvements often revolving around advances in agricultural science.

The language of improvement used by Blith does not correspond to the pursuit of increasing relative surplus value extraction that is identified by Marx as being a key component of capitalism. Blith claims that " Some Tenants have Advanced Land from Twenty pounds to Forty pounds per [anum]" [Blith, 1649]. Note that the fact that more surplus value may be extracted from the same piece of land, however there is no mention of the amount of labour time required to achieve this gain in agricultural yield. Nor is the language one of production efficiency, simply instead that the absolute surplus value may be increased. Here lie the remains of feudalism, as there is still a lack of the aggressive pursuit of relative surplus value extraction increase that characterises capitalism. However, there is present the re-investment of surplus value in order to improve capital used for production. This shows a clear break from the feudal laws of motion. Hence this re-emphasis the transitionary nature of this period.

Improvement ideology is treated as a moderate stance by Blith, in contrast with the other radical thinkers during his time. Aiming to pitch improvement as a solution to England's problems without necessitating social upheaval. Blith acknowledges the stark political nature of improvement in opposition to the ideology of the diggers, a small group of radicals who argued that all land should be held as the common. Blith "[questions] whether they as a society gathered together from all parts of the Nation could claim a right to any particular Common" [Blith, 1649]. In a similar attack Blith faces the Levellers, a much more mainstream movement who had contact with both Oliver Cromwell and John Locke, with their influence culminating at the Putney Debates. Blith would only accept their proposed reforms if they were able to produce a "new Jerusalem, or bring it down to us, when we shall not need to trouble our selves about greater or lesser, or any distinction of person, places, or estates, any more" [Blith, 1649]. Crucially in place of these radical political movements, he offered a pragmatic route of improvement through which he claimed he would "make the poor rich, and the rich richer, and all to live of the labour of their own hands" [Blith, 1649]. In professing the values of improvement to the soldiery of the new model army which had built the republic, Blith focuses on how it is a tool to achieve the aim of a new nation such that they will "I hope you will learn to hate Idleness wholly, as love Liberty dearly" [Blith, 1649]. Blith also presents "the lasting Improvement" as peace, reminding them to "Remember Christs Counsell, view the promised Land, and rejoyce to think of that day when your swords shall be turned into Ploughshares" [Blith, 1649]. It is clear that improvement is not only used to mean increasing agricultural yield but also as a powerful tool with which to resolve England's injustices. Furthermore, the moderation of Blith in contrast with the likes of the diggers and levellers demonstrates the fact

that improvement ideology was primarily aimed at landlords and capitalist tenants. Aiming to avoid any reform which might the balance of power too much. Improvement might be thought of a as a guiding ideology for an emerging middle class, not a mass movement. On the other hand Blith asks the tenant to ”lay aside, and doe but in charity walk with me a little through this discourse" [Blith, 1649], clearly the very idea of changing agricultural practises was enough of a cultural shock, given the continued and persistent effort Blith puts into re-assuring the reader that improvement will benefit not just them but also that he has no other end but the common good.

Some notion of increased labour efficiency through improvement does exist within the *The English Improver Improved*. However, given the infrequency with which it is mentioned it is not the main focus of this new improvement ideology. In directing himself to farmers and tenants, Blith chastises them for not being willing to accept new farming traditions, ”their forefathers have been accustomed to such a course of husbandry as they will practise, and no other, their resolution is so fixed, no issues or events whatsoever shall change them" [Blith, 1649]. In this stubbornness Blith argues tenants would lose out on potential agricultural yield increases. This section also deals with one of the only mentions of reduced labour input for increased agricultural yield as Blith assures the farmer that if he follows his suggestions ”half or one third part of so much land as many of you Till, shall with that very soyl, and half the labour and seed saved, yeeld you as much corn as all that great quantity scramblingly husbanded" [Blith, 1649]. This brief mention of decreasing labour time for increased yield i.e. increasing labour productivity, could be indicative of the beginnings of a more formalised capitalist mentality.

5.2 William Petty

William Petty was a contemporary of both Oliver Cromwell and John Locke. As the General-Physician of Cromwell’s army in Ireland he was in a unique position to comment on the role of improvement within enlightenment philosophy, and the new relationship between land and labour. Petty introduced several new concepts about how value should be derived and how society might be constructed based off this theory of value. This theory is summarised by his remark that “Labour is the father and active beginning of wealth, as the land is its mother” [Petty, 1662, p.68].

Petty more complicated and arguably accurate theory of value is an expression of the economic imperative of the time to be more competitive. As the more precise the understanding of the value of products the easier it is to maximise profits. Feudalism did not require an accurate theory of value as there was no direct market pressure on either the landlord or the direct producers which might affect production. Petty stated that “all things ought to be valued by two natural Denominations, which is Land and Labour" such that “a Ship or garment is worth such a measure of Land, with such another measure of Labour". Emphasising that a bridge between these two pillars of his theory of value should be established to “finde out a natural Par between Land and Labour, so as we might express the value by either of them alone as well or better then by both, and reduce pence into pounds" [Petty, 1662, p.45]. Petty aimed to develop a standard of “true rent" which he defined as the surplus produced by a tenant after he had “subducted his seed out of the proceed of his Harvest, and also, what himself hath both eaten and given to others in exchange for Clothes, and other Natural necessaries" [Petty, 1662, p.43]. This is a clear break from the customary tenancies that dominated the previous centuries and indicated a clear market dependence of land and rent.

The framework for Marx [Wilkinson, 1914, p.312] and John Locke’s theory of value, specifically the structure of his arguments used to justify the theory, can be seen in the works of Petty, “If a man can bring to London an ounce of Silver out of the Earth in Peru, in the same time that he can produce a bushel of Corn, then one is the natural price of the other" [Petty, 1662, p.51]. Here perhaps lies the origins of Marx’s socially necessary labour time in the determination of value[Marx, 1894, p.29]. Moreover the parallels with Locke in argument form are stark

as demonstrated in section 5.3. This similarity gives insight into the sources and theorist that influenced Locke when he produced his own the theory of value. Petty was also quick to comment on the role of improvement in building the English nation. Commenting on when improvements to land should be pursued Petty notes that one should “examine whether the labour of fetching these things even from the places where they grow wilde, or with less Culture, be not less then that of the said improvement" [Petty, 1662, p.52]. This indicates a frame of thinking in which profit and efficiency of labour are very much at the forefront of the justification. Highlighting how improvement was an expression of a transition away from the laws of motion which previously governed feudalism.

5.3 John Locke

Drawing inspiration from Petty, Bacon and Boyle, John Locke set out his labour theory of value in Chapter 5 "Of Property" in his Second treatise of Government. In “John Locke and Agrarian Capitalism" Neal Wood outlines the specific circumstances under which Locke came into contact with agriculture. Such as the fact that Locke became an absentee landlord, who was “perpetually exercised by the laxity of his tenants in paying their rents when due" [Wood, 1984, p.21]. As well as attributing to Locke the identification of a an English economy based on a triad of “landholder, tenant and labourer" [Wood, 1984, p.40]. Where the landholder was characterised as living off rents paid by tenants, who both created and sold goods. And may have even employed wage labour if their tenancy acreage was sufficiently large enough. Wood argued that with the establishment of this triad the “conception of labour as a commodity" [Wood, 1984, p.41] occurred. Through studying his theory of value one can gain insight into how improvement ideology affected the theorist of agricultural capitalism.

Locke uses the improvement of land as an argument for land rights which were essential to maintaining the status quo of his time, a suppressed large peasant population under a parasitic landlord class. Locke’s seminal text may be split into sections focusing on Natural rights, the effects of labour on land rights, and colonialism. Locke appeals to the bible for an a priori establishment of the natural rights of man to an equal share of land, stating that “King David says (Psalm 115. 16), “[God] has given the earth to the children of men,” given it to mankind in common" [Locke, 1689, Sec.25]. This is the philosophical bedrock off of which Locke then pushes outwards towards a theory of property justifying the newly formed class relations between landlord, capitalist tenant and farmer. In Locke’s on language he aims to demonstrate “how men might come to have a property in several parts of that which God gave to mankind in common". The next keystone of Locke’s philosophical argument is man’s possession of his own body. From here on out Locke begins to take the revolutionary steps first explored by the likes of Petty but with less pragmatic intent and a much stronger ideological dogmatism. Through direct extension of Man’s ownership of his own body, any labour performed on a object extends property into said object, such that “he hath mixed his labour with it, and joined to it something that is his own, and thereby makes it his property.” thus “ by this labour something annexed to it that excludes the common right of other men” [Locke, 1689, Sec.27]. This imbuing of property through labour may be seen as a synthesis of Petty’s land and labour theory of value, as Locke is appealing to an improvement of the natural state of being as the source of all property rights. Locke specifically states that labour “added something to them more than Nature, the common mother of all, had done, and so they became his private right".

A direct line between a Marxist labour theory of value and Locke may be drawn, but there is a distinct and crucial break which represents an ideological chasm. Locke goes beyond not just claiming that the labour of the individual imbues property rights but that “the grass my horse has bit, the turfs my servant has cut . . . become my property without the assignation or consent of anybody . . . The labour that was mine, removing them out of that common state they were in, hath fixed my property in them". This extension of property to rights beyond

the individual betrays the notion that Locke was simply proposing a theory of value extricated from his material and class conditions, instead reinforcing Wood's argument that Locke must be viewed as a political theorist for the agrarian capitalist class.

The text may also be interpreted as a piece of propaganda aimed to quell anger at the policies implemented following improvement ideology, which often led to the dispossession of the peasantry. Improvement, Locke argues, is a god given duty man was commanded "to subdue the earth—i.e., improve it for the benefit of life and therein lay out something upon it that was his own, his labour" [Locke, 1689, Sec.31]. This appeal to God is the bedrock of Locke's justification for his theory of property and by extension a claim to authority, and must be seen as targeting contemporary resistance towards improvement of land. The main source of complaints being the removal of peasants from customary lands and enclosure of commons for the sake of improvement. Again Locke consoles the woes of those resistant, arguing that in improving land the common does not lose as "he that leaves as much as another can make use of does as good as take nothing at all" [Locke, 1689, Sec.32]. In his final propaganda push Locke aims to frame the lowly peasant as lazy and an obstacle in the path of a new England stating that god gave the common to "the use of the industrious and rational (and labour was to be his title to it); not to the fancy or covetousness of the quarrelsome and contentious" [Locke, 1689, Sec.33]. Locke, acting part philosopher and part propagandist, stitches together his previous arguments of both the go given duty of man to improve and the transitive property of ownership through labour to establish that "God, by commanding to subdue, gave authority so far to appropriate" [Locke, 1689, Sec.34].

Locke's final point of argument is to extend his previous resolutions about the role of labour and improvement in establishing the right to expropriation within England, to the new American colonies. Initially establishing a quantitative measure of the ratio of value due to nature and due to labour at $1 : 99$. Next he claims that an American "king of a large and fruitful territory there feeds, lodges, and is clad worse than a day labourer in England" due to the uni-improved nature of their lands. This state of un-cultivated land Locke deems a waste with "the benefit of it [amounting] to little more than nothing" [Locke, 1689, Sec.42]. Locke characterises these natives as backwards as they have not "joined with the rest of mankind in the consent of the use of their common money ". Money plays a crucial role in Locke's theory as it allows for the overcoming of the previously established "perishable" limit on accumulation. Once this brake is removed for Locke it is obvious that " you shall see the same man will begin presently to enlarge his possessions" [Locke, 1689, Sec.49]. Locke's theory of property sought to justify improvement, and combat contemporary resistance to enclosure. In doing so he created the theoretical framework off the back of which agricultural capitalism might entrench itself into English society. Finally, he also contributed to a theory of colonialism that saw the native as having no right to their land as they were wasting it due to a lack of improvement.

6 Conclusions

In establishing his theory of transition Brenner sought to break away from a transitionary theory that he saw as requiring pre-established capitalism that hid within a previous mode of production. Through this aim he developed a model centred around the market dependence of production as opposed to the production for survival which was the fundamental "law of motion" of feudalism. It is in this market dependence that Wood broke away from Brenner, citing instead a market imperative which forced landlord and tenant alike to adhere to a new set of laws of motion. Fundamentally feudal forces of self reproduction were diametrically opposed such that neither the feudal lord nor peasant had any incentive to carry out the reinvestment of surplus values which forms such a core element of capitalism. Improvement ideology emerged as a consequence of these new market

imperatives as tenants were forced to improve their agricultural yields in order to survive within a new state of production for sale.

The large scale studies of economic metrics such as wages, rents and agricultural prices from the medieval to modern period by the likes of Clark, have provided some doubt as to the quantitative basis of Brenner and Wood's claim's. With studies of arable versus pasture prices and agricultural productivity appearing to contradict the timeline for agricultural capitalism set out by Brenner and Wood. On the other hand, similar studies into rent values show volatile behaviour in beginning in the mid 16th. This behaviour lends weight to the idea of market imperatives were being introduced into the English economy through the rental market during this time frame. This is reinforced by increases in grain output over the period, which might reflect increasing agricultural yields via improvement, either through better agricultural practices or land reclamation. Whilst both of these factors definitely lend credibility to the claims made by Brenner and Wood, further study is required into establishing a firm quantitative link between volatility in the rental market and improvement as a reaction to this impulse. Furthermore in addressing the theoretical differences between Brenner and Wood, a prediction of how each variant would be reflected in quantitative metrics such as those investigated also require further study.

Political theorists and philosophers such as William Petty and John Locke emerged during the golden period of agricultural capitalism in the latter half of the 17th Century. In the case of William Petty, he developed an initial theoretical framework based on the two tenants of land and labour as representing all value. This framework was then moulded by Locke into his labour theory of value. Within his argument Locke acts as a propagandist for the land owning class of England, appealing to God in his justification of property rights through labour and improvement. By analysing the language of classic improvement texts such as *The English Improver Improved* a precise meaning of improvement in its historical context may be found. To authors such as Walter Blith, the ideology of improvement is one that affects all facets of English society and could right almost all wrongs, preaching with equal enthusiasm to the largest landlord and to the lowest farmer about the benefits improvement could bring to their lives. In the majority of the text, improvement is used to express an increase absolute yield from a given acreage, and only rarely is it used to mean an increasing labour efficiency. Contrasting with its use in contemporary historical analysis by Brenner and Wood where the two terms are often used interchangeably. Whilst this does not represent a fundamental problem with theories presented by either author, it does indicate the gradual process over which agricultural capitalism formed between the mid 16th and 17th centuries. With fully formed concepts of labour productivity not present when market imperatives were first active, lending credibility to Marx's lack of agency of the individual. However, the idea that improvement extended itself to "new forms and conceptions of property" [Wood, 2002a, p.107] as identified by Wood is supported by the language of *The English Improver Improved*.

In studying the transition from feudalism to capitalism there are several signifiers which may be used to analyse our current socio-economic condition. First the internal contradictions of feudalism were not overcome until a very long time after its inception, regardless of the ecological disasters and Malthusian cycles it faced. This is emphasised by the alternatives to agricultural capitalism seen in the rest of feudal Europe such as absolutism in France and Spain, or a regression back into serfdom in Poland. According to Marx the internal contradictions of capitalism must lead to its collapse.However, if the collapse of feudalism is taken as an example, this collapse may take much longer than expected due to the tenacity of capitalism to evolve over its internal contradictions. The existence of alternatives to agricultural capitalism at the time of feudalism collapse may be associated with the locality of feudalism's economic outreach and the fact that it did not require continual growth of its markets. On the other hand due to the expansive nature of capitalism it is unlikely that another mode of production will be able to co-exist with it, as this would represent an area capital has not reached. Hence the laws of motion for capital

will lead it to pursue this unexploited market. The recent evolution of labour relations in 21st Century capitalism through innovations such as the gig or sharing economy must be viewed in the same light as the changes feudalism undertook, such as bastard feudalism. Even though the sharing economy is different from 20th Century capitalism the fundamental laws of motion have not changed and until they do the same contradictions will be present. The same way in which variations within feudalism didn't solve the its internal contradiction between the lord and peasant, it just alleviated them.

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